LIGHTEN YOUR LOAD · AUSTRALIAN PRODUCE GUIDE

The Dirty Dozen AU



If you only switch a few things to organic, start here. These are the 12 fruits and vegetables with the strongest Australian evidence of pesticide residues, ranked by how solid that evidence is. If you're feeding kids or you're pregnant, they're the ones that matter most.

---

1 

Strawberries

Buy Organic

10% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011, second only to apples among fresh produce (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). In CHOICE's 2008 test of strawberries from 31 growers, one sample exceeded the Australian legal limit and two more exceeded stricter EU limits for captan. Unpublished government data, obtained under FOI by Guardian Australia, showed dimethoate at up to 90× the Australian MRL. Dimethoate: banned in the EU since 2019; possible human carcinogen (US EPA).

2 

Apples

Buy Organic

Highest pesticide detection count in AU monitoring data 2000–2011 (Friends of the Earth Melbourne). The Food Standards Code sets apple residue limits for 136 chemicals. Post-harvest diphenylamine widely used (banned EU).

3 

Spinach & leafy greens

Buy Organic

Large surface area absorbs systemic pesticides that cannot be washed off. Consistent highest-risk class globally and in AU monitoring data.

4 

Grapes

Buy Organic

6.4% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011. Multiple fungicides applied repeatedly. Thin skin — cannot be peeled.

5 

Stone fruit

peaches, nectarines, apricots, plums, cherries (most stone fruit: limited AU data)

Buy Organic

Unpublished government testing (2013), revealed under FOI by Guardian Australia, found fenthion at unacceptable levels in nine peach samples and one apricot. Fenthion has since been withdrawn in Australia. PFAS fludioxonil found on 90% of peach & plum samples (EWG 2026).

6 

Blueberries

Buy Organic

Chlorpyrifos & thiometon detected in AU blueberries (FSANZ 2011). Southern Cross University (2025): 3 samples had dimethoate at levels that could exceed the safe daily intake if eaten daily. APVMA suspended dimethoate use on blueberries, raspberries and blackberries (November 2025).

7 

Pears

Buy Organic

9.5% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011 — third among fresh produce, after apples and strawberries (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). High fungicide use. Diphenylamine post-harvest (banned EU).

8 

Raspberries & blackberries

Buy Organic

91% of blackberry samples had detectable pesticides, avg 4+ per sample (EWG 2026). PFAS bifenthrin detected. Same APVMA dimethoate suspension covers raspberries & blackberries (2025).

9 

Lettuce

Buy Organic

4.1% of all AU pesticide detections 2000–2011 (Friends of the Earth Melbourne, 2012). No outer skin — entire surface is eaten.

10 

Capsicum / bell peppers

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS monitoring data. Thin edible skin. Ranks just below the Dirty Dozen globally on overall pesticide toxicity.

11 

Celery

Buy Organic

Named in AU ATDS data. No outer peel — every stalk surface is exposed. Very high surface area-to-volume ratio. 64 different pesticides detected internationally.

12 

Kale & Asian greens

Buy Organic

High pest pressure, systemic pesticide use documented. Limited AU-specific testing but biology identical to highest-risk leafy class. Tops EWG 2026 on toxicity weighting.

Where to start

- **You eat it every day.** Your most frequent buys make the biggest difference.
- **Your kids eat it a lot.** Children take in more for their size and clear pesticides more slowly than adults.
- **Money's tight.** Focus on #1–6, where the Australian evidence is strongest.
- **You're pregnant.** Strawberries, leafy greens and stone fruit especially.
- **It's imported.** Other countries may allow chemicals that are banned here.



Tip

Grow your own greens. Spinach, lettuce, kale and silverbeet are among the easiest things to grow in a pot or a patch, and they're some of the hardest to clean of residues. A few pots of greens takes a big item off this list.

Sources: FSANZ ATDS · Friends of the Earth Melbourne (2012) · CHOICE · NRS · APVMA · EWG Shopper's Guide (2026) · Guardian AU FOI · Southern Cross University (2025) · Pesticide Action Australia · Full source list →